

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Classical Dances of India - I



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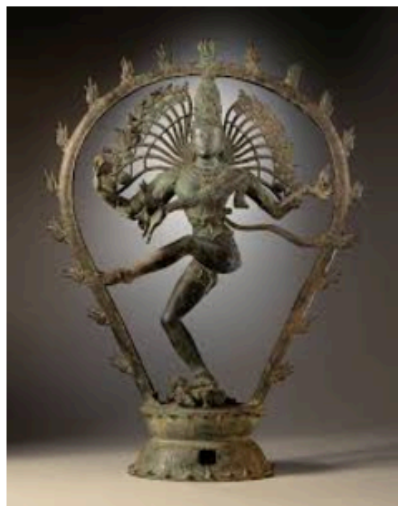
Introduction

- The classical dances of India are based on the **principles of Natya Shastra**, an ancient Indian treatise on the performing arts **written by the sage Bharata Muni**.
- As per Natya Shastra, there are two basic aspects of
 - **Indian classical dance: Tandava and Lasya**
- **Tandava (movement & rhythm)**: This symbolizes the masculine aspects of dance.
- **Lasya (grace, bhava, rasa & abhinaya)**: It is symbolic of the feminine features of dance.
- The three fundamental components of dance as described in **Abhinaya Darpan** by Nandikeshwara are:

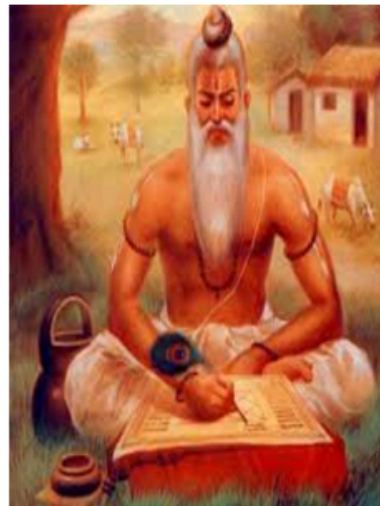
Nritta: This refers to the basic dance movements performed without any emotional expression or mood.

Natya: It involves dramatic expressions that are conveyed and elaborated through the medium of dance.

Nritya: This emphasizes the portrayal of emotions and sentiments through dance, evoking specific feelings in the audience.



(Natya Shastra)



(Bharat Muni)

- Each form of classical dance reflects the distinct culture, music, and language of the region from which it originated, yet they share common elements such as storytelling, devotion, and the portrayal of human emotions or rasas.

There are nine rasas or emotions that are expressed through the dance.

RASAS	EXPRESSION
Shringaara	Love
Rudra	Anger
Bibhatsa	Disgust
Veera	Heroism
Shaant	Peace and tranquillity
Haasya	Laughter and comedy
Karuna	Tragedy
Bhayanak	Horror
Adbhuta	Wonder

- The conveyance of emotions and expressions is achieved through the use of mudras, which involve a combination of hand gestures and body postures.
- There are 108 fundamental mudras, a combination of which is used to depict a particular emotion.
- The performers often depict stories from Hindu epics like the Mahabharata and Ramayana, and the dances are accompanied by traditional Indian music that enhances the emotive quality of the performance.
- The **Sangeet Natak Akademi** has recognized **eight** classical dance forms:
 - Kathakali, Mohiniyattam, Odissi, Manipuri, Kathak, and Sattriya, Bharatanatyam, Kuchipudi
- The **Ministry of Culture** has recognized **nine** classical dance forms
 - Bharatanatyam, Kuchipudi, Kathakali, Mohiniyattam, Odissi, Manipuri, Kathak, Sattriya, and Chhau.

Classical Dances of India

Bharatanatyam (Tamil Nadu)

- It originates from Tamil Nadu, **Bharatanatyam** is one of the oldest and most popular classical dance forms in India.
- It is deeply rooted in the spiritual and cultural traditions of South India and was initially performed by Devadasis (temple dancers) as an offering to the deities in Hindu temples.
- Over time, it has evolved into a widely performed classical art, blending artistic expression with devotional fervour
- The word "**Bharatanatyam**" is often interpreted as a combination of:
 - **Bha:** Bhava (expression),
 - **Ra:** Raga (music),
 - **Ta:** Tala (rhythm),
 - **Natyam:** (dance)



- Bharatanatyam is known for its structured, geometric movements, emphasizing lines, symmetry, and balance.
- **Dancers use intricate footwork, hand gestures (mudras), facial expressions (abhinaya), and poses to tell stories and express emotions.**
- The dance form is built on both nritya (pure dance) and nritya (expressive dance).
- The dance primarily focuses on devotion and storytelling, often depicting tales from Hindu mythology, particularly those related to Lord Shiva, Lord Vishnu, and Goddess Parvati.
- **Bharatanatyam is typically performed in Carnatic music, the classical music system of South India.**

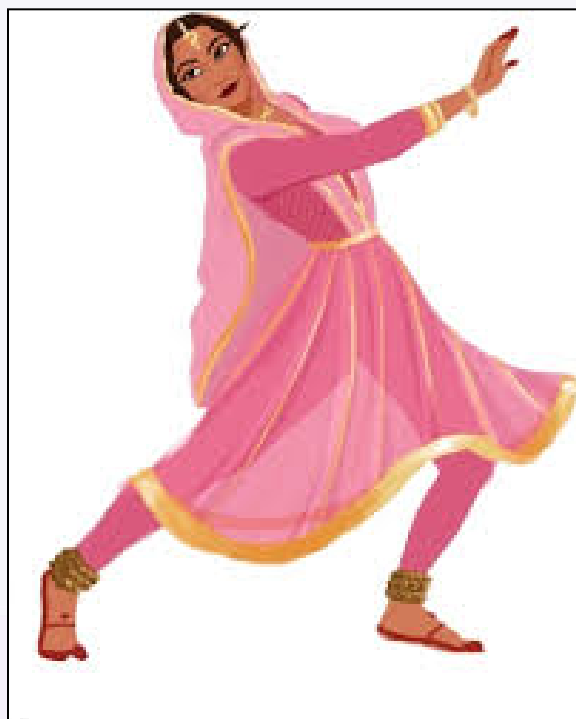
Famous Bharatanatyam Dancers:

Dancers	Pictures
Rukmini Devi Arundale: • She is credited with reviving and modernizing Bharatanatyam in the 20th century by taking it from temples to proscenium stages.	
Yamini Krishnamurthy: • She is known for her dynamic performances and mastery of the art form.	

Padma Subrahmanyam: • She is Renowned for her extensive research on Bharatanatyam and its history.	
Other famous Dancers	Sonal Man Singh, T Balasaraswati, S.K Saroj, Rama Gopal, Leela Samson, Mrinalini Vikram, Malvika Sarkar, Pridarshini Govind, Hema Malini etc

Kathak (North India)

- One of India's most popular classical dance forms originated in the northern region and is known for its intricate footwork, graceful movements, and rapid spins.
- **The origin of Kathak is from The Ras Leela of Brajbhoomi.**
- The classical style of **Kathak** was revived by Lady **Leela Sokhey** in the twentieth century.
- Kathak is generally accompanied by **dhrupad music**. Taranas, thumris and ghazals were also introduced during the Mughal period.
- The name "**Kathak**" is derived from the Sanskrit word **Katha**, meaning "**story**," as the dance was traditionally performed by Kathakars.



- Kathak dancers use expressive gestures and facial expressions to convey stories, often drawn from Hindu epics and devotional narratives of Lord Krishna's life.
- **Kathak is usually performed in Hindustani classical music.**
- **The tabla (drum)** plays a central role, providing the rhythmic foundation, along with the **harmonium, sarangi, and sitar for melodic accompaniment.**
- **Tala (rhythmic cycle) and Laya (tempo) are crucial in Kathak,** with dancers and musicians often improvising complex rhythms in perfect sync.

Famous Kathak Dancers:

Dancers	Pictures
Pandit Birju Maharaj: • The most well-known figure in Kathak, renowned for his mastery and innovations in the dance form.	
Kumudini Lakhia: • A leading Kathak dancer and choreographer who modernized Kathak and expanded its boundaries.	
Sitara Devi: • A celebrated Kathak dancer who was known as the "Empress of Dance" for her contributions to popularizing the art form.	

<u>Other famous Dancers</u>	Shovana Narayan ,Kumudini Lakhia, Damayanti Joshi,Aditi Mangaldas, Saswati Sen, Maya Rao,Lacchu Maharaj
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Gharanas in Kathak

Kathak is divided into several gharanas (schools) that have distinct styles:

Gharanas	Proponents
Lucknow Gharana: It is known for its emphasis on expressive storytelling and delicate movements. Established in the 18th century in the courts of the Nawabs of Awadh (Lucknow), particularly under Nawab Wajid Ali Shah.	Pandit Birju Maharaj: Arguably the most famous Kathak dancer, he hails from a long line of Lucknow Gharana masters.
	Shambhu Maharaj: One of the most respected exponents of the Lucknow Gharana, and a master of abhinaya, contributed significantly to the lyrical and expressive aspects of the Gharana.
	Sitara Devi: Another prominent figure who embodied the grace, beauty, and expressiveness of the Lucknow Gharana. She was known as the “Queen of Kathak.”
Jaipur Gharana: It is famous for its focus on strong footwork and intricate rhythms. This gharana developed in the courts of the Rajput kings of Rajasthan, particularly Jaipur. The style is strongly influenced by the region's	Pandit Durga Lal: A master of the Jaipur Gharana, known for his powerful footwork and expertise in rhythm. He helped popularize the vigorous style of this gharana worldwide.

martial traditions.	Rajendra Gangani: One of the foremost exponents of the Jaipur Gharana today, known for his mastery over intricate rhythms, footwork, and spins.
Banaras Gharana: It is known for its inclusion of both footwork and storytelling, with a spiritual emphasis. The Banaras (Varanasi) Gharana evolved in the religious and spiritual setting of Varanasi. It is often associated with temple performances and devotional music.	Kundan Lal Gangani: Another renowned name, known for his role in preserving and promoting the Jaipur Gharana's unique style.
	Janaki Prasad: Known as the founder of the Banaras Gharana, Janaki Prasad shaped the spiritual and devotional elements of this school.
	Sitara Devi: Though closely associated with the Lucknow Gharana, she also performed in the Banaras Gharana style, reflecting her deep connection with the spiritual aspects of the dance.
	Saswati Sen: A noted disciple of Pandit Birju Maharaj, she has also performed extensively in the Banaras style, combining storytelling with devotional aspects.

Kathakali (Kerala)

- Kathakali is a highly stylized classical dance-drama that originated in the state of **Kerala, India**.
- It is known for its elaborate costumes, intricate makeup, and vibrant storytelling, Kathakali is one of the most distinguished art forms of Indian classical dance.

- It combines elements of dance, drama, and music to convey tales from Hindu epics, particularly the Ramayana and Mahabharata.
- The dance form employs a wide range of mudras (hand gestures) and abhinaya (expressive movements) to narrate stories.
- The facial expressions and eye movements play a crucial role in conveying emotions and character traits, allowing the audience to connect with the narrative.
- Kathakali was revitalized in the 1930s by the renowned Malayali poet V. N. Menon, with support from Mukunda Raja.
- **It primarily features an all-male troupe of performers.**
- **Kathakali is also referred to as the "ballad of the East."**
- The language of the Kathakali songs is Manipravalam, a blend of Malayalam and Sanskrit.
- Kathakali is performed to a live orchestra, which includes instruments such as:
 - **Chenda:** A cylindrical drum that provides the primary rhythm.
 - **Maddalam:** Another type of drum, played with both hands.
 - **Vocalists:** Singers narrate the story through traditional verses while accompanying the dancers.
 - **The music is based on Carnatic classical traditions** and enhances the emotional intensity of the performance.



Famous Kathakali Dancers

- **Kalamandalam Gopi:** A renowned Kathakali artist celebrated for his portrayal of various roles.

- **Kottakkal Sivaraman:** A master of Kathakali known for his intricate storytelling and expressive performances.
- **Other famous Dancers:** Uday Shankar, K.Krishnan Nair, Shanta Rao.

